The Course Master Method — Pilot Syllabus

Dates: October 5 to November 23, 2026 — five sessions, then two weeks to build and record, then feedback **Instructor:** Dr. Lawrence Gray **Class Meetings:** five live sessions on Google Meet at 11 AM MT — Mondays October 5 and 12, Tuesdays October 20, 27 and November 3 (the last two run about an hour). **The module build and the recorded teach-back are due together on Tuesday, November 17**; instructor feedback follows the week of November 23. **Location:** Course materials on GitHub — https://github.com/lawrencegray-brt/how_to_build_a_course
(no account needed; click the green **Code** button, then **Download ZIP**) **Office Hours:** By appointment

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PROGRAM DESCRIPTION

This five-week pilot teaches subject-matter experts a repeatable method for building high-quality courses and training — the same method behind the program's flagship courses. It is hands-on and production-focused: you bring a real subject you want to teach, and you leave with a real course-in-progress, not notes about course design.

Through instructor-led sessions and guided production between meetings, you will turn a subject into measurable learning objectives, a Master Design Document, and one fully-built module — applying values-first design, Bloom's taxonomy, research-based teaching practices, and GenAI production under guardrails. No prior course-design experience is required.

The pilot mirrors the method it teaches: each module is delivered in the same three-package structure (instructor materials, student materials, a portable teaching guide) you are learning to build, so you experience the method while learning it.

COURSE-LEVEL LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Upon successful completion, you will be able to:

1. Write course- and module-level learning objectives using Bloom's measurable verbs.
2. Audit a course design against the seven research-based teaching practices to find gaps.
3. Produce a complete Master Design Document for a course.
4. Build one fully-realized module across all three packages (instructor, student, teaching guide).
5. Direct GenAI to draft materials and evaluate its output against guardrails for correctness and tone.
6. Embed your organization's values into course activities and assessments.

7. Apply accessibility (UDL) principles so your course works for diverse learners.
8. Plan how to evaluate a delivered course and improve it for the next run.

READINGS AND COURSE MATERIALS

All materials are provided in your Participant Packet:

- **How to Build a Course** — the method guide (your reference all five weeks; Bloom verbs and the practice question bank are in its appendices).
- **Blank templates** — Decisions document, Master Design Document, Seven-Practices audit, and the medium-neutral Module Skeleton.
- **The Contact-Hour companion** — for sizing a module to its time.
- **Two worked examples** — Intro-to-ML (a code course) and Home Coffee Brewing (a non-code course) — copy from whichever fits your subject.

Access to a GenAI tool (e.g., ChatGPT or Claude) is expected for the production work. An **agent-capable** tool — VS Code with Copilot in agent mode, or Claude Code — is optional; it unlocks the steps the Guide and the Directing AI card tag **RUN**, where the AI reads your course folder and does the work itself.

ASSESSMENT

This pilot is assessed on a **completed / not-completed basis — there are no letter grades.** You will receive constructive feedback on every deliverable. Success means producing the three deliverables to the standard of the rubrics (shared in Week 1) and a module you could genuinely hand to someone else to teach.

The three deliverables:

- **A — Learning Objectives** (Weeks 1–2): course objectives first (Week 1), then the module objectives that ladder up to them, written once you decompose into modules (Week 2).
- **B — Master Design Document** (Week 2): every module mapped — objectives, topics, materials, activities, values.
- **C — One complete module, built and taught** (Weeks 3–5): structured (Wk 3), produced with GenAI (Wk 4), and taught as a **10-minute recorded teach-back** of one segment, submitted with the module folder two weeks after Session 5 and returned with instructor feedback on the module rubric. The minimum that counts is one segment, complete.

ASSIGNMENTS

- **Pre-work** — short reading/preparation before each session so live time is spent producing, not lecturing. Includes coming to Session 1 with the subject you want to build a course on.

- **Live sessions** — five required 2-hour Zoom meetings of instruction, guided building, and feedback. Attendance expected.
- **Between-session production** — the real work: drafting your objectives, MDD, and module. In Week 4 you also run a **Review Council** review of your module and revise, keeping a short AI-direction + verification log.
- **Teach-back** — you record a 10-minute segment of your module, taught from your own teaching guide, watch it back once and write a half-page retro, and submit both with your module folder. Feedback is from the instructor, on Rubric 5.3 — met / not yet, no scores. Peer feedback is optional and was not used in the first cohort.

WEEKLY SCHEDULE

Week	Pre-work	Live session (2 hr)	Deliverable / by next week
1 — Decide & Write Objectives	Skim the guide; **bring your subject**	Decisions before production; Bloom objectives; fix-the-weak-objective pair work	**Deliverable A (part 1)** — finish Decisions doc + course objectives
2 — Master Design Document	Read the seven practices; audit your objectives	Feedback on objectives; build your MDD	**Deliverable B** — write module objectives as you decompose, finish the MDD, choose your one module
3 — Structure the Module	MDD final; module chosen	Three-package structure; scaffolding; accessibility (UDL); sketch your module skeleton	Flesh out the skeleton — structure, not content yet

Week	Pre-work	Live session (2 hr)	Deliverable / by next week
4 — Produce With GenAI	Skeleton laid out; Skeleton Map	The production loop — complete first, everything derived; when the AI doesn't know your subject; the loop with an agent (the folder as context, modes, permissions, sub-agents, skill files); the four checks, by name	Build the module to the floor (one segment at minimum); keep the AI-direction + verification log; run the Review Council and the accessibility pass if you get there
5 — Evaluate & Improve, and the Recorded Teach-Back	Keep building; read §9 and *Teaching It Well*	How the course ends; Rubric 5.3 as what the instructor looks for; evaluate & improve with your recording as the first run; Teaching It Well; the close	**Deliverable C** — the module (floor) and a 10-minute recorded teach-back, due together two weeks later; feedback the week after